

Japanese Theater Shares Cultural Similarities in Britain

A playhouse in London, Britain and a theater from Osaka, Japan, are working together to prove cultural differences between the two countries are only on the surface.

London's Charing Cross Theatre and Osaka's Umeda Arts Theater first worked together on a performance in 2019. After a break caused by the pandemic, they are jointly staging two plays in London this month. The plays are rooted in Japanese culture and deal with secretive relationships, but the concerns are universal.

Actor Susan Momoko Hingley spoke of Japan's export of culture, including films and television series. She told the Reuters news agency, "It's really about getting great stories from all sorts of different cultures to Britain and to the West."

Actors Susan Momoko Hingley and Mark Takeshi Ota perform in the production of "One Small Step" in London, Britain, September 27, 2024. (Umeda Arts Theater/ Mark Senior/Handout via REUTERS)

She stars in One Small Step, written by Takuya Kato. It tells the story of a couple working for a company that is colonizing the moon. The plot becomes more complex with the news the woman is pregnant. It raises concerns audiences almost anywhere can relate to about motherhood, career and inequality between men and women.

All about equality

Kato, who is also the play's director, said, "In terms of equity, I think nowadays many people often say that we are striving for fairness within companies, within societies and between individuals."

"But I think it is something that we understand with our heads but might not necessarily grasp it with our hearts," he added.

The London production, Kato said, gave new life to his play "at the intersection of two different cultures." He noted that for Japanese creative industries, the market within Japan may not be enough to support them. Working with companies in other countries helps the theater companies and expands knowledge of the culture.

"If we don't grow the part of coproductions, which we have traditionally struggled with, it would be difficult to survive as both an industry and culture in the future," he said.

Actor Mark Takeshi Ota performs in the production of "One Small Step", a play by Takuya Kato in London, Britain, September 27, 2024. (Umeda Arts Theater/ Mark Senior/Handout via

REUTERS)

Second play to come

Following *One Small Step*, which runs until October 9, Charing Cross Theatre will host *Tattooer* later in the month. The play, by another Japanese writer, Takuya Kaneshima, tells the story of a tattoo artist.

I'm Jill Robbins.

Marie-Louise Gumuchian and Barbara Lewis reported this story for Reuters. Jill Robbins adapted it for Learning English.

Vocabulary

stage - v. จัดแสดง (ละคร, การแสดง ฯลฯ) บนเวที

audience - n. ผู้ชม, ผู้ฟัง, ผู้ชมการแสดง

strive - v. มุ่งมั่น, พยายามอย่างหนักเพื่อทำหรือบรรลุบางสิ่ง

grasp - v. เข้าใจ (สิ่งที่มีความซับซ้อนหรือยาก) อย่างถ่องแท้

intersection - n. จุดตัด, จุดที่สองสิ่งหรือมากกว่ามาบรรจบกัน

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What is the primary goal of the collaboration between the London and Osaka theaters?

- To introduce Japanese language to British audiences.
- To highlight the deep cultural differences between the two countries.
- To demonstrate that cultural differences are merely superficial.
- To compete with other international theater groups.

2. When did London's Charing Cross Theatre and Osaka's Umeda Arts Theater first collaborate on a performance?

- This month.
- In 2024.
- After the pandemic.
- In 2019.

3. According to the article, what kind of concerns do the currently staged plays address?

- Mainly historical events unique to Japan.
- Secretive relationships and universal human concerns.

Modern political issues in Britain.

The challenges of colonizing the moon.

4. What does actor Susan Momoko Hingley believe is the significance of Japan's export of culture?

It primarily aims to boost Japan's economy.

It is about bringing great stories from diverse cultures to the West.

It helps Japan maintain its cultural uniqueness.

It focuses on promoting Japanese films and TV series exclusively.

5. What is the core plot of the play "One Small Step"?

A historical drama about Japanese explorers.

A romantic comedy set in London.

A story about a couple working for a company colonizing the moon, complicated by pregnancy.

A documentary about space travel.

6. What universal concerns does the play "One Small Step" raise for its audiences?

The dangers of space travel and alien encounters.

Motherhood, career choices, and gender inequality.

Financial crises and corporate espionage.

The development of new technologies and artificial intelligence.

7. According to Takuya Kato, what do many people often say they are striving for nowadays regarding equity?

Financial growth within companies.

Fairness within companies, societies, and among individuals.

Technological advancements in the arts.

Greater cultural exchange globally.

8. What does Kato suggest about how people understand fairness?

They fully grasp it with both their heads and hearts.

They understand it intellectually but may not feel it deeply.

They struggle to understand it intellectually.

They only grasp it when experiencing it personally.

9. How did the London production benefit Takuya Kato's play?

It helped Kato secure more funding from Japan.

It provided the play with a new life at the intersection of two cultures.

It changed the play's original plot entirely.

It allowed the play to be performed only in Japanese.

10. Why might Japanese creative industries seek international collaborations?

To prevent cultural appropriation.

To reduce their reliance on domestic talent.

Because the market within Japan may not be sufficient to support them.

To exclusively target Western audiences.

11. According to Kato, what is essential for the future survival of Japanese theater as an industry and culture?

Reducing the number of productions.

Focusing solely on traditional Japanese plays.

Growing the part of coproductions, which they have traditionally struggled with.

Increasing government subsidies.

12. What is the name of the second play that Charing Cross Theatre will host?

One Small Step

The Moon Colonists

Tattooer

Japanese Dreams

13. Who is the writer of the second play, "Tattooer"?

Takuya Kato

Susan Momoko Hingley

Takuya Kaneshima

Mark Takeshi Ota

14. What is the subject matter of the play "Tattooer"?

A historical account of Japanese art.

The life story of a tattoo artist.

The struggles of a colonist on the moon.

A romance set in modern Japan.

15. Who adapted the original Reuters story for VOA Learning English?

Marie-Louise Gumuchian

Barbara Lewis

Takuya Kato

Jill Robbins